

# Structure and Functions of Government in Pakistan

In Pakistan, the government operates under a parliamentary democratic framework based on the Constitution of 1973, with a structure divided into three main branches:

## 1. Executive Branch

The Executive is responsible for implementing laws, administering public policies, and managing day-to-day governance. It includes the **Head of State**, **Head of Government**, **Cabinet**, and **Provincial Governments**.

- ❖ **Head of State:** The President, who is the ceremonial figurehead with limited powers, largely representative and diplomatic in nature. The President is elected by the Electoral College for a five-year term.
- ❖ **Head of Government:** The Prime Minister, who holds the most executive power, is responsible for running the government and implementing laws. The Prime Minister is elected by the National Assembly.
- ❖ **Cabinet:** The Prime Minister appoints a Cabinet of ministers responsible for various government departments, like finance, defense, and education.
- ❖ **Provincial Governments:** Pakistan has four provinces (Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and Balochistan), each with its own provincial assembly and Chief Minister. Provincial governments have jurisdiction over certain areas, such as health and education, but also share powers with the federal government.

## 2. Legislative Branch

The Legislative branch is responsible for making laws, discussing national issues, and overseeing the executive branch. Pakistan's Parliament is **bicameral**, consisting of the **National Assembly** (lower house) and the **Senate** (upper house).

- ❖ **National Assembly (Lower House):** The primary legislative body, composed of elected representatives. Members are elected for five-year terms, and each province's representation depends on its population.
- ❖ **Senate (Upper House):** The Senate serves as a balancing body between provinces, with equal representation from each province regardless of population size. Senators serve six-year terms, and elections for half the Senate are held every three years.
- ❖ **Provincial Assemblies:** Each province has its own legislative assembly to pass laws within provincial jurisdiction.

## 3. Judiciary

The Judiciary in Pakistan is an independent branch of government that interprets laws, protects citizens' rights, and resolves disputes. It upholds the Constitution and ensures that executive and legislative actions comply with the rule of law.

- ❖ **Supreme Court:** The apex court in Pakistan that interprets the Constitution, has the power of judicial review, and addresses disputes between the federal and provincial governments.
- ❖ **High Courts:** Each province has a High Court for overseeing legal matters within the province.
- ❖ **Lower Courts:** These include District and Session Courts that handle civil and criminal cases at the district level.

The functions of the government are to uphold the Constitution, protect citizens' rights, and ensure law and order while fostering economic growth and social development. Pakistan's government operates through a separation of powers where each branch has distinct responsibilities, though they are also interdependent.

# The Relationship Between Democracy and Civil Society

## 1. What is Civil Society?

Civil society includes all non-governmental organizations, community groups, social movements, and other voluntary organizations that work to express the interests and values of citizens. Examples of civil society organizations include NGOs, advocacy groups, charities, trade unions, and think tanks.

The relationship between democracy and civil society is deeply interconnected, with each reinforcing and supporting the other. In a democratic society, civil society plays a crucial role by providing a platform for citizens to express their views, participate in governance, and hold authorities accountable.

## 2. The Role of Civil Society in Democracy

Civil society is crucial in a democratic society because it:

- **Promotes Citizen Participation:** Civil society enables people to participate in governance outside of electoral politics by voicing their opinions, advocating for rights, and engaging in community improvement.
- **Holds the Government Accountable:** Organizations monitor government actions, check corruption, and push for transparency.
- **Encourages Inclusivity and Representation:** Civil society represents diverse interests that may otherwise be marginalized in formal political processes.
- **Educates and Mobilizes Citizens:** Civil society groups educate citizens on their rights and responsibilities, often mobilizing communities to demand better governance.

## 3. Democracy and Civil Society in Pakistan

In Pakistan, civil society has played an influential role, often **acting as a bridge between the government and the people**. Civil society organizations in Pakistan address a range of issues, including **human rights, gender equality, education, and environmental protection**. However, they face challenges **such as restrictive regulations, limited funding, and political pressure**. The vibrancy of civil society is essential for Pakistan's democratic system, as it ensures diverse voices are heard and helps keep the government accountable.

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